

A Dhāraṇī and Mantra for Pacifying the Illnesses of Phlegm

Toh 801 · Derge Kangyur

བད་ཀན་གཞིན་སལེ་བའ་གི་ཟུང་སྒྲུལ།

The Dhāraṇī for Pacifying the Illnesses of Phlegm (Tibetan: Bé kän gyi né sel wé zung ngak) is a very short text, catalogued as Toh 801 in the Kangyur, belonging to the class of dhāraṇī and mantra texts. It opens with homage to the Noble Lord Avalokiteśvara and gives a brief mantra beginning "Om śānti śānti," a formula of pacification, followed by a list of ailments it is meant to relieve, including indigestion, swelling, tumors, and wasting. As its title indicates, the text concerns illnesses of phlegm, one of the three humors in Tibetan and Indian medical thought, and it offers a ritual remedy through recitation in place of a medical treatise. The Sanskrit title is not given in the opening lines, so it is described here only in general terms. Its place in the Kangyur reflects the canon's broad collection of protective and healing mantras.

A dhāraṇī and mantra for pacifying the illnesses of phlegm.

Homage to the Noble Lord Avalokiteśvara.

Om śānti śānti, bhiti śānti, sarva biti mula myaga sasvāhā.

Indigestion of food, and swelling, and tumors, and wasting...

Translator's Notes

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, so the list of ailments is left incomplete. The mantra is rendered in reconstructed form from the Tibetan transliteration. Its middle syllables (bhiti, biti, mula myaga sasva) are corrupt or unclear and cannot be reliably restored to standard Sanskrit, so they are given as transliterated. "Phlegm" translates the Tibetan term for the phlegm humor (badkan) of Tibetan medicine, one of the three humors. The terms "swelling" and "wasting" are tentative: the Tibetan words so spelled can denote swelling or inflammation and loss of strength or wasting, and in a medical context their exact sense is somewhat uncertain.

Colophon

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Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.